

Chapter 78-3

"What happened here?" Liang Shi asked.

"Mom—" Liang Xinhe was about to say, but was sharply interrupted by Liang Xinzhou. "Liang Xinhe."

Liang Xinhe sheepishly closed his mouth.

Liang Xinzhou explained, "I accidentally scratched myself."

But Liang Shi had heard what Liang Xinhe said. She looked at Liang Xinzhou and said helplessly, "You'd have to be pretty careless to scratch yourself there."

As she spoke, she stood up. "You two chat first. I'll be back in a bit."

After she left, Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe finally began discussing the situation they would face tonight.

Without a doubt, when the Liang parents brought back the long-lost biological sister, the whole family would feel awkward.

Awkwardness was secondary—the main issue was not knowing how to arrange things afterward.

As children, they really had no way to stop their parents from doing what they were determined to do.

However, Liang Xinhe first brought up the earlier matter. "Big Brother, I think you're overthinking this. How capable can someone from the countryside be? Can she really stir up that much trouble? You're being too paranoid."

"Then you should think about it more carefully." Liang Xinzhou put away his tablet. "How can someone from the countryside build up a self-media presence in less than half a year, and do it so successfully at that? She's clearly skilled at manipulating public opinion. Mom and Dad are blinded by their 'biological daughter' filter right now—are you blinded too?"

"No," Liang Xinhe denied. "I'm just trying to find a middle ground, aren't I? Otherwise, before our biological sister even comes back, this family will already be torn apart."

"There's no middle ground to be found." Liang Xinzhou sighed. "When you saw Mom arguing with Liang Shi, you should have known that there's no middle ground in this matter."

There was no option to have both.

It would only create rifts with both.

"But that biological sister is also quite pitiful," Liang Xinhe said. "She has no relatives left over there. Did you see what she wrote on Weibo? First her mother died, then her father died. She was raised by her grandmother all along, and it wasn't until her grandmother was on her deathbed that she was told she wasn't biological."

By the end, Liang Xinhe's tone carried a note of sorrow. "She's also always been called a jinx and a harbinger of death.¹ She's this old and no one dares to pursue her. Fate is truly cruel."

"So what?" Liang Xinzhou asked.

Liang Xinhe was stunned and looked at Liang Xinzhou with some shock. "Big Brother, aren't you being too cold? You can't even spare her a bit of pity? She's still our biological sis—"

Liang Xinzhou's stern gaze fixed firmly on Liang Xinhe, causing Liang Xinhe's voice to grow lower and lower until he couldn't continue.

Liang Xinzhou shook his head. "She's very pitiful, but... I'm skeptical about it."

"What do you mean?" Liang Xinhe asked. "These things can't all be made up, can they? If they were, someone from her village would surely come out and refute her. This kind of thing can be easily verified."

"I'm not saying she made it up," Liang Xinzhou said. "But there's definitely some exaggeration. Just based on that pinned Weibo post of hers, I'm skeptical. The word choice and sentence structure don't look like something written by someone who never went to college."

Liang Xinhe: "..."

"Can't she just be good at Chinese?" Liang Xinhe said sheepishly.

Liang Xinzhou stared at him, utterly speechless.

A few seconds later, he said with exasperation, "Read her Weibo post a few more times and you'll understand."

Liang Xinhe touched the tip of his nose, too embarrassed to say anything more.

Liang Shi only raised her hand to knock on the door after the argument between the two had subsided. She had gone downstairs to get iodine and band-aids. After entering, she handed them to Liang Xinzhou, but Liang Xinzhou waved his hand. "It's just a small wound. No need."

"Even a small wound is still on your face," Liang Shi said. "How could you be so careless? It won't be good if it leaves a scar later."

Liang Xinzhou stubbornly refused to let her treat it, but Liang Shi said helplessly, "Just listen to me this once."

Liang Xinzhou: "..."

Liang Shi disinfected the wound near his nose bridge, then used office scissors to cut the band-aid into small pieces and stuck them on, trying her best to make it less noticeable that there was a band-aid there.

After throwing all the scraps into the trash bin, she asked, "Where are you two headed?"

"Home," the two said in unison.

Liang Shi nodded. "Alright then, I'm going home too. Be careful on the road."

She didn't ask a single thing about the real heiress.

Before leaving, Liang Shi also said to Liang Xinhe, "Oh right, Second Brother, I'll still come to work tomorrow, but I won't be coming starting next week."

Liang Xinhe nodded. "Got it."

The two brothers watched Liang Shi's departing figure.

Liang Xinhe sighed with emotion. "Liang Shi has really changed."

"Growing up happens in an instant," Liang Xinzhou said. "Her rebellious phase is over, so naturally she's better now. Don't you think she's a lot like how she was as a child?"

Liang Xinhe: "...Is she?"

Liang Xinzhou nodded. "You spent less time with her, so you didn't notice."

"By the way, what did you say in the study last time about what Mom did to Liang Shi?" Liang Xinhe suddenly said. "Wasn't Liang Shi always the one Mom spoiled the most? I was never as favored as Ah Shi in front of her."

"Excessive indulgence," Liang Xinzhou said in a low voice. "Indulgence without boundaries. And Mom once gave Liang Shi to Qin Lishuang."

"Qin Lishuang?" Liang Xinhe frowned. "That painter who likes to do body art? She's the youngest daughter of the Qin family, right? Over forty and still unmarried."

"Yes." Liang Xinzhou let out a soft breath. "After I found out, I went to bring Liang Shi out, but Liang Shi had already spent one night with her... When I asked what happened, she wouldn't say."

"What the hell." Liang Xinhe was agitated. "What kind of messed up situation is this? Why would Mom give Liang Shi to her? Our family isn't at the point where we need to ask favors from people."

"It wasn't about asking for favors," Liang Xinzhou explained. "Mom said she didn't know. Qin Lishuang only told her she wanted to borrow Liang Shi as a model. She thought it would be culturally enriching and good for Liang Shi, so she let her guard down. To be precise, she didn't 'give' her away—she just let Liang Shi help as a model. But given Qin Lishuang's character..."

Liang Xinzhou's voice grew heavy. "I don't find that believable."

"Of course it's not believable," Liang Xinhe lowered his voice. "A friend of mine had a younger sister who was taken away by Qin Lishuang under the pretense of modeling, and she ended up... ruined."

"What?"

"She..." Liang Xinhe paused, then said in a muffled voice, "The kind where she can never have children again."

"Fuck." Even someone as composed as Liang Xinzhou couldn't help but let out a curse.

He still remembered the scene when he went to find Liang Shi, barging into Qin Lishuang's villa with people.

Rumors in the outside world said that Qin Lishuang was a crazy artist who would sleep with many people to find inspiration, and would also observe many people's bodies. Qin Lishuang would pay handsomely for it. Because the Qin family was considered a prestigious family in Haizhou City, and they also had marriage ties with the Lu family, a prominent family in the capital, no one said anything. Many things were just passed around within their circles.

People would just chat about it as idle gossip over tea.

When he found Liang Shi, she was wearing a black leather jacket, her hair tied up in a ponytail, wearing heavy makeup, with a terrible expression on her face.

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1. "掃把星" (sàobǎ xīng, literally "broom star") and "喪門星" (sāngmén xīng, literally "funeral door star") are Chinese superstitious terms for someone believed to bring bad luck or misfortune to those around them. These are deeply hurtful labels in Chinese culture, suggesting that the person's presence causes death or disaster. ↩